The Balkan Investor's Guide to Dubai

Regional tax comparison · Three emirates · Financing · Currency strategy · Updated July 2026

AED 419.9B
DUBAI H1 2026 TRANSACTIONS

0%
INCOME & CAPITAL GAINS TAX

6.58%
DUBAI AVG GROSS YIELD

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

For Balkan investors navigating currency volatility, bureaucratic friction, and thin yields, the UAE offers a structural alternative: zero income and capital gains tax, 6.5–9% gross yields, full foreign ownership, and a USD-pegged currency that ends depreciation risk.

BALKANS VS UAE: TAX COMPARISON

Tax type	Balkans (avg)	UAE	Advantage
Income tax on rentals	10–25%	0%	Keep 100% of rent
Capital gains tax	10–20%	0%	No tax on profits
Property transfer tax	2–5%	4% DLD	Comparable or lower
Annual property tax	0.1–1%	0%	No holding cost
Currency risk	High (non-EUR)	AED pegged to USD	No depreciation risk
Net rental yield	3–5%	5–6.5%	30–50% higher net

COUNTRY-BY-COUNTRY

Country	Income tax	CGT	Transfer	Currency
Serbia	10–15%	15%	2.5%	RSD (volatile)
Bosnia & Herz.	10% flat	10%	2–5%	BAM (EUR-pegged)
Croatia	20–30%	12–25%	3%	EUR
Albania	15% flat	15%	2–3%	ALL (volatile)
Montenegro	9–15%	9–15%	3%	EUR
UAE	**0%**	**0%**	**4% DLD**	**AED (USD peg)**

THREE EMIRATES FOR BALKAN CAPITAL

Emirate	Entry/sqft	Gross yield	Catalyst	Best for
Dubai	AED 1,300–4,200+	6.5–8%	Al Maktoum Airport, Dubai 2040	Liquidity & depth
Abu Dhabi	AED 900–2,500	5–7%	Saadiyat Cultural District	Stability & yield
Ras Al Khaimah	AED 1,000–1,600	7–9%	Wynn Al Marjan, Spring 2027	Highest yield

RESIDENCY

10-year Golden Visa requires property worth AED 2M+ (since Feb 2026, off-plan qualifies on the registered Oqood price — no minimum paid equity; mortgaged properties qualify with a bank NOC). Properties from AED 750K qualify for a 2-year renewable residence visa (Taskeen).

THE BOTTOM LINE

Regional currencies depreciate 2–8% a year against hard currency. The AED doesn't. Every year of waiting costs Balkan investors twice — once in yield forgone, once in currency lost.

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MR Living Capital · Investment Advisory · BRN 94316 · mrlivingcapital.com · mrlivingcapital@gmail.com · Sources: Dubai Land Department H1 2026; official UAE government visa guidance (Feb 2026); Property Finder Demand Index Q2 2026; Engel & Völkers / Property Monitor (Jan–Jun 2026). For information only — not financial advice. Published July 2026.